

AI Manager Activation Playbook

A manager operating guide for building AI into how teams work.

— WELCOME!

Managers make AI **real.**

Every investment Fabletics makes in AI becomes meaningful when managers help their teams work differently. You do not need to become an AI expert — you need to become the leader who helps your team continuously improve.

An operating model, not another program

This playbook introduces the operating model behind five leadership behaviors and points you to the practical tools that put them into practice.

It is not a technical manual, and it is not another training program. It is a practical guide for leading AI-enabled improvement with your team.

MANAGERS...

identify opportunities

improve workflows

strengthen quality

build new habits

recognize progress

That is Manager Activation.

WHY MANAGERS MATTER

Managers translate AI strategy into daily team practice.

They decide where AI gets discussed, where time gets protected, what gets improved, what gets recognized, and what becomes a team habit.

TOOLS & TRAINING

create **awareness**.



MANAGERS

turn awareness into repeated practice.

Managers lead the improvement process, not every answer.

Managers do not need to identify every AI opportunity, design every solution, or become the technical expert for every tool. Their responsibility is to create the process and conditions that help the team find meaningful opportunities, test better approaches, and learn from the results.

MANAGERS ARE RESPONSIBLE FOR

- ✓ Creating focus around work that matters
- ✓ Asking questions that help the team examine the work
- ✓ Giving employees time and permission to experiment
- ✓ Setting clear expectations for quality and judgment
- ✓ Coaching the team through testing and refinement
- ✓ Reinforcing and sharing practices that work

MANAGERS ARE NOT RESPONSIBLE FOR

- Arriving with a complete solution
- Personally redesigning every workflow
- Knowing every available AI tool
- Approving every small experiment before it begins
- Turning every idea into a formal project

From building AI capability to improving how teams work

From individual use to team improvement.

WHAT WE HAVE BUILT: INDIVIDUAL CAPABILITY

Training

Experimentation

Personal productivity

One-off use cases



WHAT MANAGERS ACTIVATE

1. Improve the Work

Apply AI to workflows, decisions, and important outputs.

2. Better Ways of Working

Turn improvements into repeatable team practices.

Managers activate the shift by creating focus, time, expectations, and reinforcement.

Build improvement into existing routines

The goal is not another AI meeting. It is making improvement part of how the team already operates. Lead with the question.

TEAM MEETINGS Surface opportunities, learning, and useful practices. ASK THE TEAM "Where did AI help us improve the work this week?"	1:1's Coach application and help remove barriers. ASK THE TEAM "Where could you apply what you already know to work differently?"	WORK REVIEWS Examine quality, judgment, and results. ASK THE TEAM "What became stronger, and what still requires human judgment?"	PLANNING CONVERSATIONS Choose the next opportunity and clarify the outcome. ASK THE TEAM "Which part of this work would be most valuable to improve?"	AI WEEKLY LEARNING HOUR Protected time — Fridays, 10–11AM PT — for AI learning. ASK THE TEAM "How will your team use this time?"
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How to use this playbook

Read the model first, then act with your team. Start with the work, not the tool — one opportunity is enough to begin.

01 Read to understand

Understand the expectations and the operating model behind the behaviors.

02 Use the toolkit to act

Reach for the toolkit when you are ready to take action with your team.

03 Start with one, then build

Begin with one behavior and one opportunity. Build the habit before expanding.

04 Use sprint kits for structure

Use the sprint kits when you want a structured meeting-in-a-box experience.

The two ways managers improve work

Every opportunity starts with one question: **What needs to improve?**

THE WORK



PATH ONE

WORKFLOW IMPROVEMENT

Improve **how work gets done.**

PATH TWO

CAPABILITY ENHANCEMENT

Improve **the quality of the work.**

Improve how work gets done

Use when work is repetitive, slow, manual, inconsistent, or full of friction — and redesign the flow so the same work takes less effort next time.



USE IT WHEN:

Work is repetitive, slow, manual, inconsistent, or full of friction.

SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE:

The same work takes less effort next time.

Improve the quality of the work

Use this path when work needs stronger thinking, better decisions, clearer communication, or higher-quality outputs.

SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE:

The work itself is better than before.



HOW THE TWO WORK TOGETHER

Every improvement opportunity starts with **one question:**
What needs to improve?

**WORKFLOW
IMPROVEMENT**

strengthens the **system of work**.

+

CAPABILITY ENHANCEMENT

elevates the **value of the work itself**.

The two paths are complementary. Workflow Improvement strengthens the system of work. Capability Enhancement elevates the value of the work itself.

The Manager Activation Loop

Five connected behaviors, one continuous loop — two lead the work, three lead the team.

LEAD THE WORK

REDESIGN 02

Guide the team in improving how work gets done and the value it creates.

IDENTIFY 01

Help the team surface and prioritize meaningful opportunities.



LEAD THE TEAM

03 REINFORCE

Make AI-enabled improvement part of recurring team routines.

04 ENABLE

Create time, support, clarity, and safety to experiment.

05 RECOGNIZE

Highlight progress, share learning, and encourage reuse.

Five behaviors turn AI leadership into everyday management practice.

THE CONTINUOUS CYCLE

Identify → **Redesign** ↻

Spot the opportunity, improve the work, and make it stick — then begin again as work changes.

THE STANDING CONDITIONS

Enable + **Reinforce** + **Recognize**

People need time, safety, clarity, and visible reinforcement to keep experimenting and improving.

The toolkit, mapped to the loop

Start with a leadership need, pick the resource, and see the behavior it supports — grouped by the two halves of the loop.

LEAD THE WORK

	Identify / Redesign
Workflow Mapping Guide Use when — you are unsure which workflow to improve first.	IDENTIFY
Workflow Improvement Sprint Kit Use when — work is repetitive, slow, manual, or inconsistent.	REDESIGN
Workflow Improvement Canvas + Cards Use when — running the sprint or working independently.	REDESIGN
Capability Enhancement Sprint Kit Use when — work needs stronger thinking or higher-quality outputs.	REDESIGN
Capability Enhancement Canvas + Cards Use when — improving existing work or creating new value.	REDESIGN
AI Work Quality Review Guide Use when — reviewing important AI-assisted outputs.	REDESIGN

LEAD THE TEAM

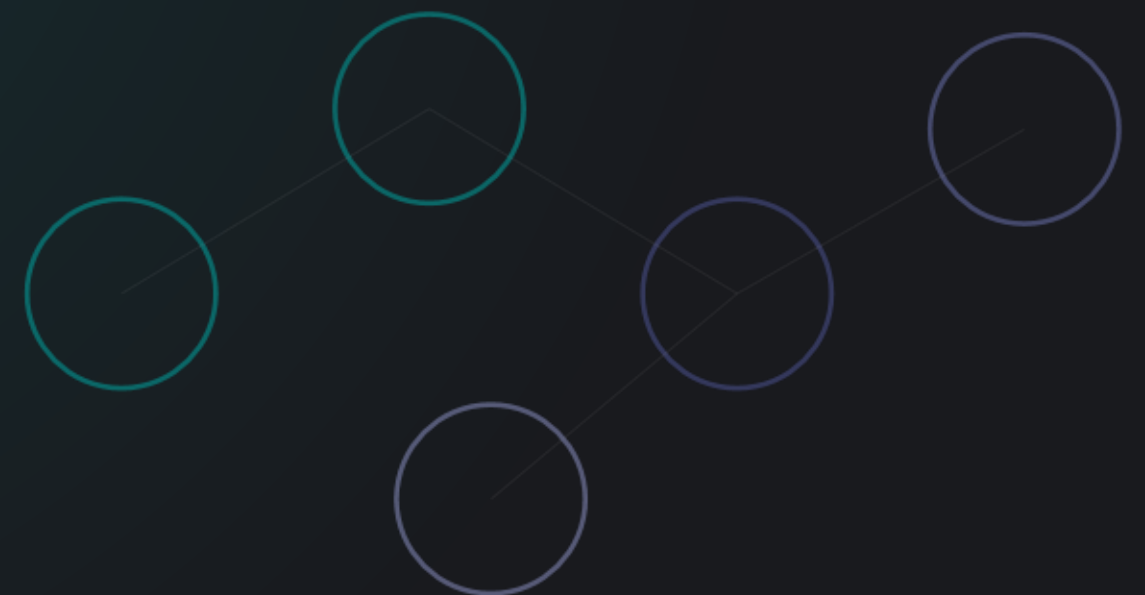
	Reinforce · Enable · Recognize
AI as Thought Partner Guide Use when — AI should improve judgment, not just produce content.	ENABLE
Psychological Safety + Guardrails Guide Use when — the team needs permission and clarity to experiment.	ENABLE
Team AI Review Use when — making AI improvement part of the team rhythm.	REINFORCE
Manager Conversation Guide Use when — reinforcing and recognizing AI through conversations.	REINFORCE / RECOGNIZE

Start with the work, not the tool. One opportunity is enough to begin.

SECTION · THE FIVE BEHAVIORS

The Five Behaviors

Managers build AI-enabled improvement through five connected behaviors. Focus on one at a time.



01

LEAD THE WORK

IDENTIFY

Spot opportunities where AI can create meaningful value.

WHY IT MATTERS

The best AI improvements begin with the right opportunity. Managers help teams look at the work, name what is worth improving, and prioritize the places where AI can create the most value.

WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE

- Regularly asks where work feels harder than it should.
- Helps the team distinguish workflow opportunities from capability opportunities.
- Starts with the work and the desired outcome, not the tool.
- Prioritizes the highest-value opportunities instead of chasing every idea.
- Revisits opportunities as work changes.

THE MINDSET SHIFT

“My team will figure out where AI fits if they need it.”

→

“I create the space for my team to identify and prioritize opportunities together.”

Manager prompt – what one small action will you take this week?

START HERE: RESOURCES

Workflow Mapping Guide

Find repeatable work and friction points.

Sprint Selector

Decide Workflow vs Capability.

Team AI Review

Surface patterns and recurring blockers.

02

LEAD THE WORK

REDESIGN

Improve how work gets done and how value gets created.

WHY IT MATTERS

Redesign turns opportunities into better ways of working — sometimes simplifying a repeatable workflow, sometimes strengthening the quality of an important work product. The goal is to create something the team can use again.

WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE

- Improves one opportunity at a time.
- Chooses the right sprint for the improvement goal.
- Uses the canvas to guide the work instead of jumping straight to tools.
- Turns useful outputs into reusable assets, practices, or examples.
- Refines what works after real use.

THE MINDSET SHIFT

~~“AI is something we add to the way we already work.”~~

→

“AI is a reason to rethink how the work should happen.”

Manager prompt – what one small action will you take this week?

START HERE: RESOURCES

Workflow Improvement Sprint Kit

Improve a repeatable workflow.

Capability Enhancement Sprint Kit

Stronger thinking, decisions, outputs.

Asset Library Guidance

Save what works for reuse.

03

LEAD THE TEAM

REINFORCE

Make AI part of everyday team habits.

WHY IT MATTERS

Reinforcement is how experimentation becomes practice. AI becomes part of how the team works when it shows up in recurring conversations, operating rhythms, reviews, and follow-through.

WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE

- Keeps AI visible in team meetings and 1:1s.
- Protects time for learning and experimentation.
- Uses Team AI Reviews to look for patterns, not just isolated wins.
- Encourages people to share what they tried and what they learned.
- Connects improvements to actual business outcomes.

THE MINDSET SHIFT

"I have already talked about AI with my team."

→

"AI is part of how our team works every week."

Manager prompt – what one small action will you take this week?

START HERE: RESOURCES

Team AI Review

Monthly wins, blockers, next steps.

Manager Conversation Guide

Team meeting and 1:1 prompts.

Operating Rhythms

Weekly, monthly, quarterly habits.



Create the conditions that make experimentation possible.

WHY IT MATTERS

Teams adopt AI faster when expectations are clear, time is protected, and experimentation feels safe. Enablement is not just access to tools — it is the environment that makes using those tools realistic.

WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE

- Protects real time for learning and experimentation.
- Clarifies what is in bounds and what requires checking first.
- Normalizes experiments that do not work.
- Coaches through mistakes with curiosity.
- Encourages higher-quality AI use, not just more AI use.

THE MINDSET SHIFT

“Everyone has access, so the team is enabled.”

→

“Everyone has permission, time, support, and guardrails.”

Manager prompt — what one small action will you take this week?

START HERE: RESOURCES

Psychological Safety Guide

Confidence to experiment.

AI Guardrails

Clarify what is green, yellow, or red.

AI as Thought Partner Guide

Use AI to improve thinking.

05

LEAD THE TEAM

RECOGNIZE

Reinforce progress by celebrating meaningful AI wins.

WHY IT MATTERS

Recognition turns isolated improvements into shared practices. When managers name what worked, why it mattered, and how others can use it, they help successful behaviors spread.

WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE

- Recognizes specific behaviors and outcomes.
- Celebrates small improvements as well as big wins.
- Shares useful examples beyond the immediate team.
- Connects people solving similar problems.
- Uses recognition to reinforce the habits the team should repeat.

THE MINDSET SHIFT

“If the work is good, people will notice.” → “I actively spot, name, and share AI wins.”

Manager prompt – what one small action will you take this week?

START HERE: RESOURCES

Manager Conversation Guide

Recognition and sharing language.

Team AI Review

Surface and discuss team wins.

Recognition & Sharing Resources

Share a win more broadly.

— BUILD THE HABIT

The Manager Activation Rhythm

The five behaviors become easier when they are built into a simple rhythm. The goal is not another standing meeting or initiative — use the moments that already exist to keep improvement visible.

Every week, every month, every quarter

Every week

Small conversations



Ask your team what they are trying, what is working, and what could be improved.

Every month

Sprint or review



Run a sprint or Team AI Review. Choose one opportunity, work on it, and capture what is worth reusing.

Every quarter

Reflect & reset



Reflect, recognize, and reset priorities. Share what worked and choose the next focus area.

Start small. Build consistency. Let it grow.

Month 1 / 30 Days

Learn the system and start the conversation

Read this playbook. Introduce AI as a standing topic with your team. Use the Sprint Selector to identify one opportunity. Decide on a Workflow or Capability Sprint.

Month 2 / 60 Days

Run the work and capture what helps

Run your first sprint. Use the relevant canvas and Quick Start Cards. Capture one reusable asset, practice, or example. Bring one learning into a meeting or 1:1.

Month 3 / 90 Days

Build the habit

Hold your first Team AI Review. Recognize one meaningful AI win. Update your team asset library or examples. Choose the next improvement opportunity.

Team AI Scorecard

The AI Team Review Scorecard is an **optional** monthly check in that helps you see where **progress** is happening, where **support** is still needed, and which **wins** are worth capturing.

FIND ON [START.ai](#)

MANAGER ACTIVATION - MONTHLY PULSE

AI Team Review Scorecard

A quick monthly check on how you're leading AI with your team. Fill it in during your Team AI Review — it takes less than 10 minutes.

MANAGER

TEAM

MONTH

PART 1 - BEHAVIOR CHECK

One quick read on each behavior in the Manager Activation Loop.

Identify

Are we spotting the right opportunities?

We named at least one opportunity to improve this month

Doing this

Starting to

Not yet

We know if it's a Workflow or Capability opportunity

Doing this

Starting to

Not yet

I made space for the team to surface ideas, not just me

Doing this

Starting to

Not yet

Redesign

Are we improving the work, not just adding AI to it?

We ran or continued a sprint (Workflow or Capability)

Doing this

Starting to

Not yet

We rethought the process or output, not just bolted on a tool

Doing this

Starting to

Not yet

Something from this month is reusable (prompt, template, SOP, asset)

Doing this

Starting to

Not yet

Reinforce

Is AI part of how we already operate?

AI came up in a team meeting or 1:1 this month

Doing this

Starting to

Not yet

We protected time for learning or experimentation

Doing this

Starting to

Not yet

We looked back at wins, blockers, and next steps

Doing this

Starting to

Not yet

Enable

Do people feel safe and clear to experiment?

The team knows what's green, yellow, and red to try

Doing this

Starting to

Not yet

I coached through at least one mistake with curiosity, not correction

Doing this

Starting to

Not yet

Time and permission to experiment felt real, not theoretical

Doing this

Starting to

Not yet

Recognize

Are we celebrating what's working?

I called out at least one specific AI win by name

Doing this

Starting to

Not yet

The win was shared beyond just our team (Champs, Show & Tell, cross-functional team share-out, etc.)

Doing this

Starting to

Not yet

Recognition pointed to a behavior we want repeated

Doing this

Starting to

Not yet

PART 2 - IMPROVEMENT TRACKER

Where the team's Workflow and Capability work actually stands.

Workflow Improvement

Improving how the work gets done.

CURRENT OPPORTUNITY

What are you improving?

STATUS

Not started

WHAT CHANGED BECAUSE OF IT

One or two lines

Capability Enhancement

Improving the quality of the work produced.

CURRENT OPPORTUNITY

What are you improving?

STATUS

Not started

WHAT CHANGED BECAUSE OF IT

One or two lines

THIS MONTH'S WIN

What's worth recognizing?

NEXT MONTH'S FOCUS

What's next?

WHAT'S BLOCKING US, IF ANYTHING

Optional

— CLOSING THOUGHT

AI is the accelerator. Managers are the **activation system**.

Manager Activation is not about using AI more. It is about helping teams improve how work gets done and the quality of the work they produce.

FIND ALL RESOURCES MENTIONED IN THE PLAYBOOK ON [START.AI](#)